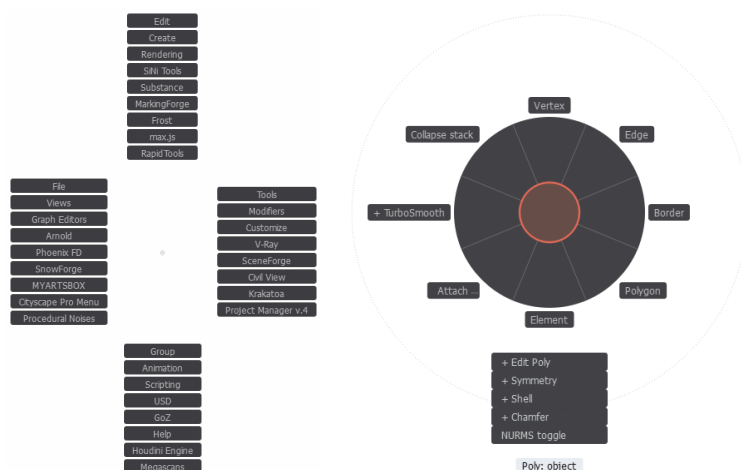


# MarkingForge

for Maya users - your marking menus and hotbox, in 3ds Max

3DS MAX 2027 · VERSION 1.5.31



## REAL MARKING MENUS - A QUICK GESTURE NEEDS NO DIAL

MarkingForge works the way marking menus are meant to: the command is chosen by the **direction** of the movement, not by clicking an item. Press the key and flick the mouse towards the command in one quick movement - the command runs and **the dial is not even drawn**. The dial appears only when you hold the key and wait, to remind you where things are. After a few days your hand knows the directions and you stop looking.

If your hand already knows Maya's marking menus, it already knows MarkingForge: hold, aim, release. This guide maps what you know from Maya to where it lives here, and sets 3ds Max up the way a Maya user expects in five minutes.

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# You already know how this works

MarkingForge brings the interaction you use in Maya every day into 3ds Max, the same way round:

## IN MAYA

Hold a key or a mouse button, a radial menu appears, drag towards an item, release. Experienced users flick without looking at the menu.



## IN MARKINGFORGE

Exactly that. Hold a key, the dial appears, aim, release - or flick without waiting for the dial. Release in the centre to cancel.

## IN MAYA

Eight compass positions, plus extra items in a list under the marking menu; sub-menus open by dragging through an item.



## IN MARKINGFORGE

Eight directions, plus up to twelve rows under the dial; submenus open by moving through their direction, three levels deep.

## IN MAYA

The right-click marking menu changes with what is under the cursor and with the component mode.



## IN MARKINGFORGE

Context variants: the same key shows different tools at vertex, edge or polygon level, on a spline, over the material editor - automatically.

## IN MAYA

Hold Space: the hotbox shows every menu at the cursor.



## IN MARKINGFORGE

The hotbox dial shows every 3ds Max menu as tiles at the cursor - including menus other plugins add. Put it on Space if you like (chapter 3).

## IN MAYA

More marking menus from the same place: each zone of the hotbox has its own marking menus, one per mouse button.



## IN MARKINGFORGE

One key can hold several sets of a dial - its pages. Hold the key and turn the mouse wheel: the next or previous page appears in place ("page 2 of 3" under the dial). The next press opens the page you turned to last.

# Maya habit - MarkingForge equivalent

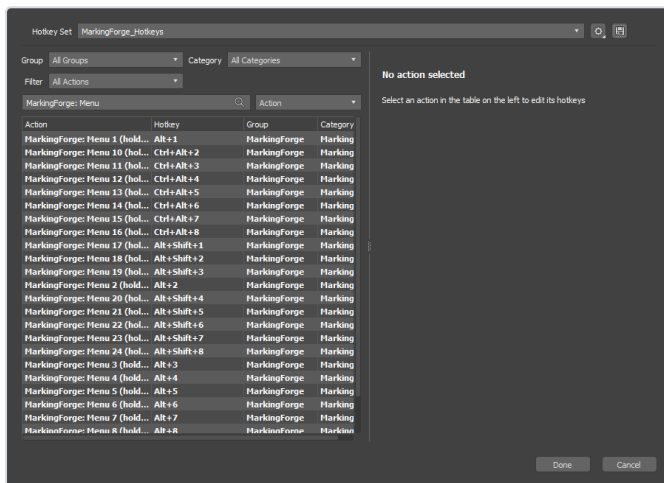
| In Maya you...                                                       | In MarkingForge                                                                                                                                                         | Notes                                                                                                                                                       |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Hold Space for the hotbox                                            | Alt+5, one mouse-wheel notch away (the hotbox page)                                                                                                                     | Or put the hotbox dial from the dial library on a key of its own - Space, chapter 3.                                                                        |
| Right-click an object to pick a component mode                       | Alt+1 on an Editable Poly at object level: Vertex N, Edge NE, Border E, Polygon SE, Element S                                                                           | 3ds Max's own keys 1-5 still work.                                                                                                                          |
| Shift + right-click for the modelling tools of the current component | Alt+1 at a sub-object level: vertex / edge / border / polygon / element tools                                                                                           | Same directions on Editable Poly and under Edit Poly - except W at polygon level (Detach / Bridge). NW goes back to object level.                           |
| Ctrl + right-click to convert the selection                          | Alt+3 at a sub-object level of an Editable Poly: To vertex, To edge, To face on three corners                                                                           | Grow / Shrink and Loop / Ring are on the same dial.                                                                                                         |
| Grow / shrink the component selection                                | Alt+3 at a sub-object level: Grow N, Shrink S                                                                                                                           |                                                                                                                                                             |
| Click an item's option box to set it up first                        | Move far past the ring before releasing: Chamfer, Extrude, Inset... open their settings (caddy); an ordinary release runs them at once - and a long flick counts as far | Per item: Settings... in the editor chooses which is the default.                                                                                           |
| Repeat the last command                                              | Alt+8 (Recent commands), north is the newest                                                                                                                            | A flick up repeats.                                                                                                                                         |
| Undo several steps                                                   | Alt+7 (Undo): each direction undoes more steps, by name                                                                                                                 | N = 1 step, NE = 2 ...                                                                                                                                      |
| Frame the selection / frame all                                      | Ctrl+Alt+7: Zoom selected SW, Zoom extents all N                                                                                                                        | 3ds Max's Z key also frames the selection.                                                                                                                  |
| Isolate the selection                                                | Ctrl+Alt+7: Isolate S                                                                                                                                                   | The same move ends the isolation.                                                                                                                           |
| Switch between perspective and orthographic views                    | Ctrl+Alt+8 (Viewports): a compass of views                                                                                                                              | Top N, Bottom S, Left W, Right E, Front SE, Back SW, Perspective NE, Camera NW.                                                                             |
| Create primitives from a marking menu                                | Alt+4 (Create)                                                                                                                                                          | Shapes when a shape is selected.                                                                                                                            |
| Reach several marking menus from one place (the hotbox zones)        | Sets of one dial: hold its key and turn the mouse wheel                                                                                                                 | Add a set in the editor with <b>New set...</b> or <b>Dial library...</b> > <b>Add as a new set of Menu N</b> ; each set has a tab over the dial's contents. |
| Build your own marking menu in the Marking Menu Editor               | MarkingForge > Menu editor...                                                                                                                                           | Any of 4000+ 3ds Max commands, 102 ready-made scripts, your own scripts, submenus. Or start from <b>Dial library...</b> or <b>New dial wizard...</b>        |
| Take your marking menus to another machine                           | Right-click a dial in the editor: save it to a .mfdial file, or <b>Save every dial...</b>                                                                               | On the other machine: <b>Load dial...</b> or <b>Load every dial...</b> Scripts from somebody else's files are removed unless you keep them.                 |
| Give a marking menu a hotkey (press / release)                       | Set shortcut... + Apply shortcuts                                                                                                                                       | Or 3ds Max's Customize > Hotkey Editor: MarkingForge: Menu 1-24.                                                                                            |
| Put a marking menu on a mouse button                                 | Mouse button (+ Ctrl / Alt / Shift) in the editor                                                                                                                       | A modifier is required - chapter 4 explains why.                                                                                                            |

# Set 3ds Max up like Maya in five minutes

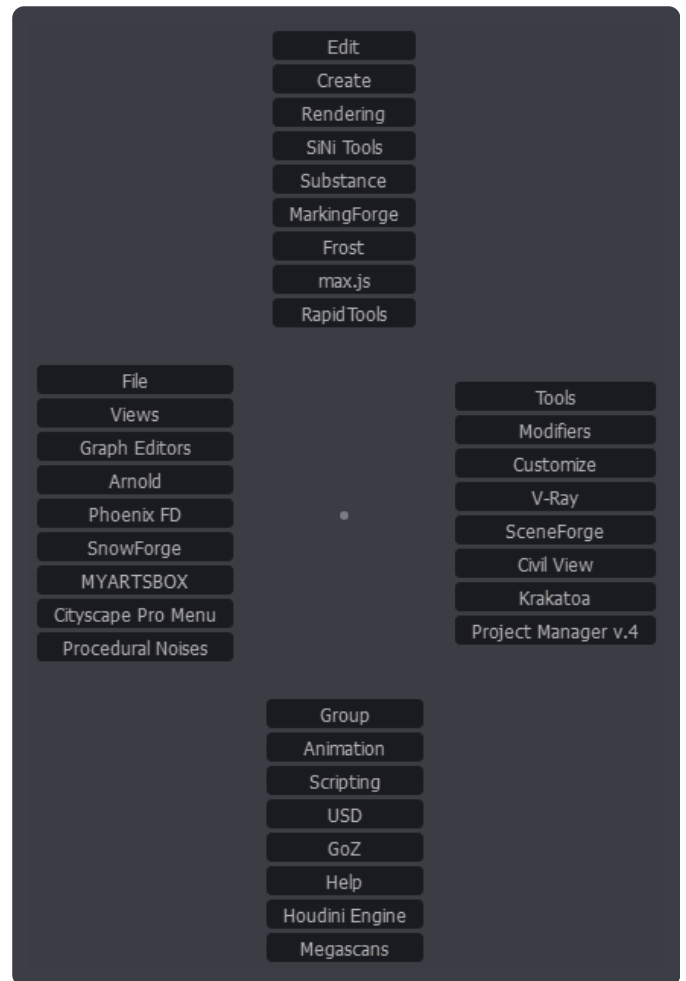
## 1. The hotbox on Space

In 3ds Max, Space toggles the selection lock. If you do not use that, give Space to the hotbox - the selection lock stays one gesture away on Alt+3 (west).

- 1 **Customize > Hotkey Editor.**
- 2 Type **MarkingForge: Menu 5** in the search field and select it.
- 3 Click the hotkey field on the right, press **Space** and assign it. 3ds Max tells you Space is used by Selection Lock Toggle - reassign.
- 4 **Done.** Hold Space in a viewport and turn the mouse wheel one notch away from you: the hotbox.



The Hotkey Editor filtered to the MarkingForge dials.



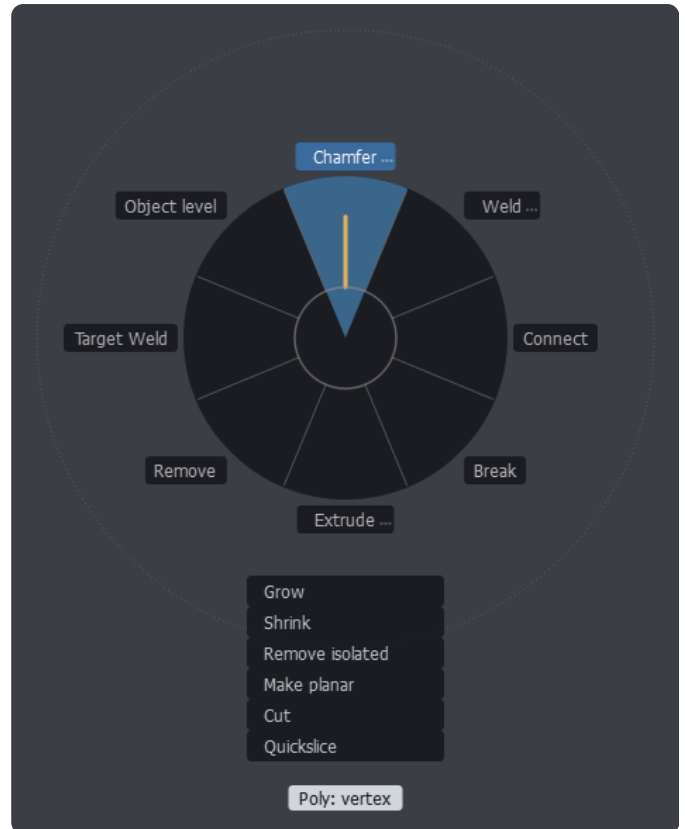
The hotbox - 3ds Max's menus around the cursor.

## 2. Component modes and tools under one key

Nothing to set up - Alt+1 already behaves like Maya's right-click and Shift + right-click menus combined. On an Editable Poly at object level it offers the component levels; at a level it offers that level's tools.

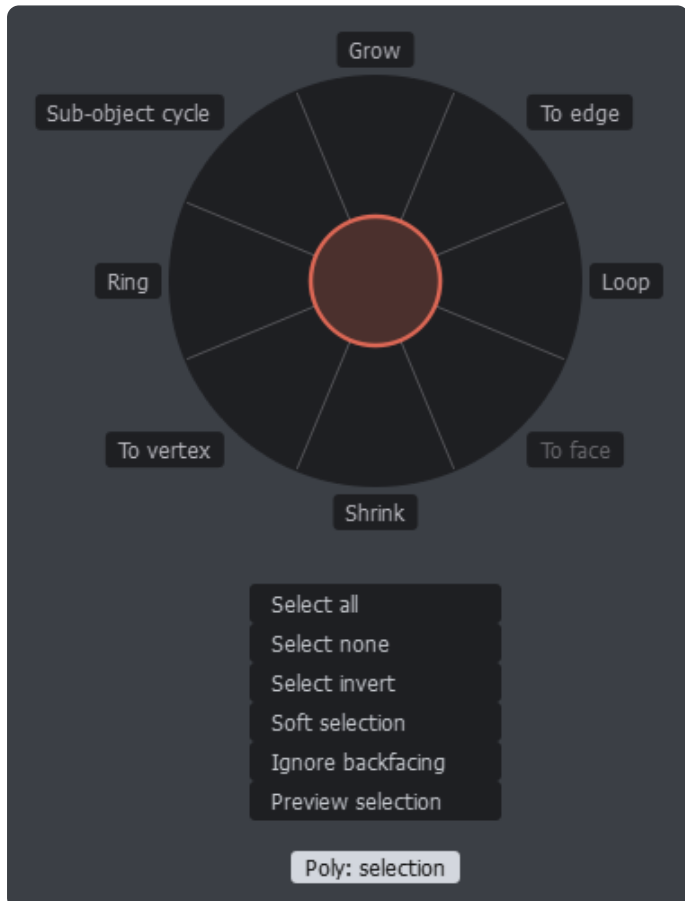


Alt+1 at object level: pick the component mode.



Alt+1 at vertex level: the vertex tools.

### 3. Selection conversion and growing

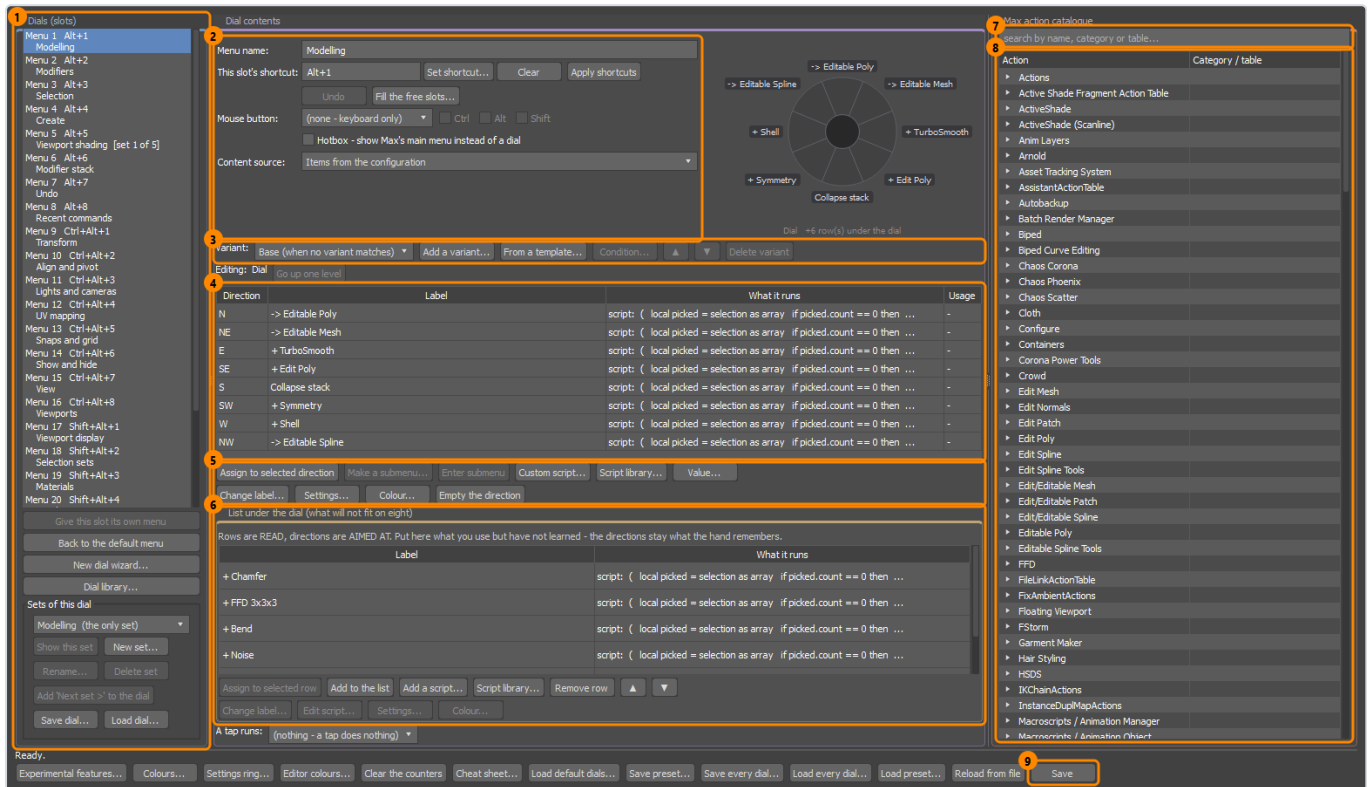


Alt+3 at a component level: Grow / Shrink, Loop / Ring, conversions on the corners.

## 4. Your most used Maya menu, rebuilt

Open **MarkingForge > Menu editor...**, pick an empty or rarely used dial and place your commands. The QuickStart walks through it step by step (tutorials 8-13).

Want to keep the dial that is there? Make your menu a **new set** of it instead (**New set...** under **Sets of this dial**): the key still opens what it opened, and the mouse wheel turns to your menu while you hold the key. **Put this set on the key** swaps them when your menu has earned the first place. The QuickStart covers sets and the dial library in tutorials 20 and 21.



The menu editor: dials, directions, and the catalogue of every 3ds Max command.

## Differences worth knowing

| Topic                   | What is different                                                                                                                                                     | Why                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|-------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Right-click menus       | Dials open on keys (or a mouse button WITH a modifier), not on a bare right-click.                                                                                    | In 3ds Max the right button opens the quad menu and every modifier + right-click combination opens another quad. Taking a bare mouse button away from 3ds Max would break it, so MarkingForge refuses. |
| Free mouse combinations | Good choices: a thumb button (XB1 / XB2) with Ctrl or Shift, or Ctrl+Shift + middle button.                                                                           | Alt + middle orbits and Ctrl+Alt + middle zooms in 3ds Max.                                                                                                                                            |
| The hotbox              | Shows 3ds Max's main menu as tiles; you point at a menu title, then at an entry and release - or click the entry, as in Maya.                                         | The MarkingForge hotbox has no marking-menu zones like Maya's - the 24 dials and their pages under the mouse wheel play that role.                                                                     |
| Option boxes            | An ordinary release runs the command at once by default; far past the ring opens its settings. A flick follows the same ring: short runs it, long opens the settings. | Configurable per item with Settings... in the editor; the ring's distance with Settings ring...                                                                                                        |
| Context                 | Chosen automatically from the sub-object level, the selection, the modifier in the panel or the window under the cursor.                                              | The first matching variant wins - you control the order in the editor.                                                                                                                                 |
| How many menus          | 24 dials on Alt, Ctrl+Alt and Shift+Alt with digits 1-8 - and any dial can hold several sets, turned with the mouse wheel.                                            | The digit is the place, the modifier the bank - easy to count to without looking.                                                                                                                      |
| The mouse wheel         | Taken only while a dial with sets is open and at its first level - it turns the page. In a submenu, the hotbox or any other time it zooms and scrolls as usual.       | One page per notch, also on a fine wheel or a touchpad.                                                                                                                                                |

3ds Max already uses **Q W E R** for select, move, rotate and scale - the same keys as Maya - so those habits carry over without MarkingForge.

## A two-week plan for a Maya hand

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| When     | Do this                                                                                                                                                         |
|----------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Day 1    | Hotbox on Space. Use Alt+1 for component modes and tools instead of the command panel.                                                                          |
| Days 2-4 | Alt+3 for selection conversion, Ctrl+Alt+7 for framing and isolating. Print the Shortcut Card.                                                                  |
| Days 5-7 | Flick the gestures you use most without waiting for the dial.                                                                                                   |
| Week 2   | Rebuild your one or two favourite Maya marking menus as MarkingForge dials in the editor - or as a second page of a dial you already use, one wheel notch away. |

Next: the **QuickStart** (tutorials with pictures) - or its **easy version**, the same lessons in plainer words - and the **Reference** (every option).

# Support, bug reports and feature requests

|         |                                                                                                                               |
|---------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| ISSUES  | <a href="https://github.com/Forge-Plugins/MarkingForge/issues">github.com/Forge-Plugins/MarkingForge/issues</a>               |
| ROADMAP | <a href="https://trello.com/b/7gJVqG8Y/markingforge-features-roadmap">trello.com/b/7gJVqG8Y/markingforge-features-roadmap</a> |
| E-MAIL  | <a href="mailto:forgeplugins@gmail.com">forgeplugins@gmail.com</a>                                                            |
| WEB     | <a href="https://forgeplugins.tech">https://forgeplugins.tech</a> (forgeplugins.tech - more plugins by the author)            |

**Bug reports and feature requests** are best opened as issues on GitHub - the forms there ask for exactly what is needed, and you can follow the fix. Questions, and anything you would rather not post publicly (licence, purchase), go to the e-mail address. Every message is read.

## Reporting a bug

- 1 In 3ds Max choose **MarkingForge > Report a bug...** - it copies your 3ds Max version, MarkingForge version, configuration summary and start-up log to the clipboard. It works even when the plugin did not load.
- 2 Open [github.com/Forge-Plugins/MarkingForge/issues](https://github.com/Forge-Plugins/MarkingForge/issues) and pick **Bug report** - or write an e-mail to [forgeplugins@gmail.com](mailto:forgeplugins@gmail.com) instead. Both are links in the window that opens (since 1.5.20), one click each.
- 3 Say what you did, what you expected and what happened instead, then paste the details with **Ctrl+V**.
- 4 Add a screenshot if you can. When the problem is in one dial, attach a preset of it (editor > **Save preset...**).

## Suggesting a feature

Open an issue with the **Feature request** form, choose **MarkingForge > Suggest a feature...**, or simply write. Describe what you would like to do and how you do it today - a concrete example from your work says more than a list of wishes. Ideas for new built-in dials, commands and options are all welcome. What is already planned and in progress is on the **Roadmap** above - **MarkingForge > Roadmap (Trello)** opens it too.

Nothing is sent by the plugin itself: the details go to the clipboard and your own e-mail program, so you see everything that leaves your computer. MarkingForge has no network access.